

- RAM: 512MB
- Hard disk: 2GB free space
- Network speed: 256 Kbits/sec
- Graphics card: 3D-capable with 32 MB of VRAM
- Screen: 1280 x 1024
- 32-bit True Colour

But wait... there's more: "To browse Bhuvan, you require the Bhuvan plug-in, which can be downloaded from this website, after registration and you will also need DirectX 9.0 or a higher version (www.microsoft.com/windows/directx/) and the MS .NET framework 2.0 or above for installing the plug-in. Please note that the Bhuvan plug-in can be installed with administrative privileges only."

Now, while they call this a 'Google Earth killer', most people can't even see if it works or not, because many don't use Windows—at all. And why should they waste money on buying a licence for an operating system just so they can run Bhuvan, when they are perfectly happy with the current OS they are using? Well, thank you for your offer GoI and ISRO, but we're perfectly okay with Google Earth—although non-free software, it still runs on GNU/Linux. And hey, the free software alternative called Marble [<http://edu.kde.org/marble>] is also out there. Why couldn't ISRO work with them, to collaborate and share, all for the greater good that benefits all?

And what's with the only-runs-on-Internet Explorer

factor? Yes, all those who're still stuck with Windows, yet have switched to Firefox or something else for their browsing needs are now required to switch back to IE if they want to use it. Seems like ISRO is doing free-of-cost PR and sales work for Microsoft (well, IE's browser market share is at an all-time low, and seems to be dipping every day) with the Indian taxpayer's money.

These Indian government bodies seem to be going where water doesn't flow freely. This is discouraging for our economy, that too for a sovereign country like India. Governments don't wake up till it's election time again. Seems like our only hope remains with the opposition parties (besides the free software community), to not let the government sell us out to proprietary corporations that are not even based on Indian soil.

A copy of the minutes of the apex body meeting is available at: http://fosscomm.in/OpenStandards/Apex_Body_Meeting_Minutes 

By Swapnil Bhartiya

A Free Software fund-a-mental-ist and Charles Bukowski fan, Swapnil also writes fiction and tries to find cracks in a proprietary company's 'paper armours'. He is a big movie buff, and prefers listening to music at such loud volumes that he's gone partially deaf when it comes to identifying anything positive about proprietary companies. Oh, and he is also the assistant editor of *EFYTimes.com*.

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